

The Corbiani Almanac

MARCH 1 - MARCH 7, 2026

Twenty pounds of broccoli, seven dinners, and the week spring finally arrives — snow on Monday, 73°F by Thursday, and a soundtrack of funk and soul carrying the family from stroganoff to slow-smoked pork.

 Elsie's No-Go List: fish

Week at a Glance

DAY	EVENTS	DINNER	ALBUM
Sun 03/01 OVERCAST 50°/33°	—	Beef & Mushroom Stroganoff over Egg Noodles	Cymande – Cymande
Mon 03/02 SNOW 37°/24°	IDP Check-in 4:10-5:00 PM	Baked Ham, Broccoli & Potato Gratin	Surprise Chef – Education & Recreation
Tue 03/03 SNOW 40°/32°	Level 4 Swim Lessons 6:00-6:30 PM	Babo Pasta — Homemade Spinach Pasta with Alfredo Sauce	Kokoroko – Could We Be More
Wed 03/04 MODERATE DRIZZLE 62°/41°	Product Day (all day)	Beef & Broccoli Stir Fry with Oyster Mushrooms	The Budos Band – Long in the Tooth
Thu 03/05 DENSE DRIZZLE 73°/54°	—	Broccoli & Oyster Mushroom Flatbread with Ricotta & Chili Honey	Nubiyan Twist – Freedom Fables
Fri 03/06 OVERCAST 59°/47°	Elsie YAT 4:30-6:00 PM	Pan-Seared Branzino with Lemon-Herb Butter & Roasted Broccoli	Marcos Valle – Garra
Sat 03/07 LIGHT DRIZZLE 73°/46°	—	BBQ Pork Butt with Broccoli Slaw	Curtis Mayfield – Superfly

Daily Plan

From Russian to American BBQ, with Cymande on the stereo

Sunday, March 1

A free Sunday at 50°F — mild enough to crack a window while you cook. The week stretches ahead with twenty pounds of broccoli to conquer, so today is all about prep and an elaborate dinner to set the tone.

Beef & Mushroom Stroganoff over Egg Noodles

RUSSIAN

A 19th-century Russian aristocratic classic, reimagined with both cremini and oyster mushrooms. Sirloin strips seared hard in a screaming-hot pan, then braised with shallots and a splash of brandy until the kitchen fills with that unmistakable stroganoff perfume — rich, earthy, slightly boozy. The silky sour cream sauce comes together in minutes and coats every ribbon of egg noodle.

sirloin steak, cremini mushrooms, oyster mushrooms, sour cream, egg noodles, shallots, brandy, Dijon mustard, paprika, broccoli

Free Sunday means time for an elaborate cook. Sear the beef in small batches so it browns rather than steams — that's where the flavor lives.

AT THE TABLE

Stroganoff is a dish people have been making for hundreds of years in Russia. If our family had one recipe we'd pass down for a hundred years, what should it be — and what story would we tell about why it's special?

At 8, Elsie is beginning to understand legacy and tradition. Connecting food to family identity helps her see herself as part of a longer story, not just a kid eating dinner. Sunday's unhurried pace makes room for this kind of big-picture thinking.

RESILIENCE

Antifragile Transitions

Some things don't just survive change — they need it to grow. This week, learn to stop bracing and start bending.

"Wind extinguishes a candle and energizes fire. Likewise with randomness, uncertainty, chaos: you want to use them, not hide from them."

— Nassim Nicholas Taleb, *Antifragile: Things That Gain from Disorder* Ch. 2

The Wind and the Candle

Picture two objects sitting on your front porch during tonight's wind advisory: a candle and a campfire. The same gust that snuffs the candle makes the campfire roar. Same wind, opposite outcomes. The difference isn't the intensity of the disruption — it's the nature of what's being disrupted. A candle is fragile: it needs calm conditions to survive. A campfire is antifragile: turbulence feeds it. Nassim Taleb opens his book with this image because it reframes a question most of us never think to ask. We spend enormous energy trying to predict and prevent disruptions — weather, schedule changes, market shifts, moods. But what if the better question isn't 'how do I avoid the wind?' but 'how do I become fire?' Taleb defines antifragility in the prologue of **Antifragile**: 'Some things benefit from shocks; they thrive and grow when exposed to volatility, randomness, disorder, and stressors.' This is not the same as toughness. Tough things endure. Antifragile things improve. Your bones get denser under impact stress. Your problem-solving gets sharper and more creative when plans collapse. The spring crocuses pushing through the last crust of snow outside your window right now needed that cold — the process of vernalization requires weeks of near-freezing temperatures before the plant can bloom.

Here's what makes this useful rather than just interesting: you can choose which category you fall into. A family that builds its week around a rigid schedule is a candle — one disruption and the whole thing gutters. A family that builds around principles and adapts the details is a fire. This week, as Reston lurches from snow to seventy-three degrees, you have a choice. You can curse the unpredictability, or you can notice that the swing itself is making your week richer — snow angels on Monday, open windows on Thursday, the particular joy of a season turning in real time. The volatility is not the enemy of a good week. It might be the ingredient. What in your life right now is set up like a candle — requiring perfect conditions to survive — when it could be restructured as a fire?

"Some things benefit from shocks; they thrive and grow when exposed to volatility, randomness, disorder, and stressors."

— Nassim Nicholas Taleb, *Antifragile*, Prologue

Reflect: What in your life right now is set up like a candle — requiring perfect stillness to survive — when it could be restructured as a fire?

FOOD52 · 4 SERVINGS · PREP 15 MIN · COOK 35 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Heat a big heavy pan, get it nice and hot. Sear the beef strips fast, two minutes each side, then get them out. Same pan, cook the onions and mushrooms with a pinch of salt until they smell like heaven and all that brown goodness lifts off the bottom. Sprinkle the flour, stir it in, then pour the brandy and let it sizzle. Add your broths, bring it to a gentle bubble, and let the beef finish cooking low and slow for twenty minutes. Cook your egg noodles till they still have a little bite. Off the heat, stir in the sour cream, a squeeze of lemon, the Dijon, and fresh dill. If you're using dried dill from a jar, honey, we need to have a talk.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

A · SEAR 2 MIN PER SIDE OVER HIGH HEAT (REMOVE)

- 1 lb sirloin steak (*sliced into 1/2-inch strips*)
- 1 tbsp vegetable oil

B · SAUTE 8 MIN UNTIL GOLDEN, ADD FLOUR, STIR 30 SEC

- 8 oz cremini mushrooms (*sliced*)
- 4 oz oyster mushrooms (*torn*)
- 1 small onion (*diced*)
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 tbsp vegetable oil
- 2 tbsp all-purpose flour

C · DEGLAZE PAN, SCRAPE FOND

- 1 1/2 cups beef broth
- 1 1/2 cups chicken broth
- 1/3 cup brandy

D · WHISK TOGETHER, SET ASIDE

- 2/3 cup sour cream
- 1 tbsp lemon juice
- 1/2 tsp Dijon mustard
- 1 tbsp fresh dill (*chopped*)
- 1/2 tsp paprika

Final: return beef, simmer 20 min → cook 1/3 lb egg noodles separately → fold sour cream mixture in off heat → serve over noodles

VARIATIONS

One-Pot Ground Beef Stroganoff — Swap sirloin for ground beef and cook the noodles directly in the sauce for a q... (recipe)

All-Mushroom Vegetarian Stroganoff — Replace beef entirely with a mix of shiitake, cremini, and oyster mushrooms for... (recipe)

Smoked Paprika Chicken Stroganoff — Use chicken thighs and double the smoked paprika for a Hungarian paprikash-lean... (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Sear the beef like you mean it — Slice sirloin thin against the grain. Get your cast-iron screaming hot — just past the smoke point of canola oil. Sear in small batches, 45 seconds per side, until you have a hard Maillard crust. Pul...

SAUCE Build a proper brandy-fond pan sauce — After searing the beef, sauté cremini and oyster mushrooms in the same pan without moving them for 3-4 minutes until deeply golden. Add minced shallots, cook 2 minutes. Deglaze with brandy — let it f...

ACID Lemon zest and chive finish — Right before plating, zest half a lemon directly over the stroganoff and scatter a generous handful of finely sliced fresh chives. The zest goes on last — heat destroys its volatile oils.

CYMANDE

Cymande

1972 · FUNK / SOUL · WARM, GROOVY,
UPLIFTING, SOULFUL

Recorded at De Lane Lea Studios in London in 1972, Cymande's debut is
the work of nine British-Caribbean musicians from...

*Warm, groovy Caribbean funk for an elaborate Sunday stroganoff cook — the kind
of music that makes stirring feel like dancing.*

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Monday, March 2

4:10-5:00 PM | IDP CHECK-IN

Snow is falling and it's 37°F — the kind of Monday where you want the oven doing all the work. An IDP check-in this afternoon, then home to a kitchen that smells like sharp cheddar and baked ham.

Baked Ham, Broccoli & Potato Gratin

AMERICAN COMFORT

A French-inspired gratin born for snow days: thick-cut ham layered with thinly sliced Yukon Golds and blanched broccoli florets, blanketed in a sharp cheddar béchamel. The technique dates back to the Dauphiné region of France, where cooks discovered that cream, cheese, and patience in a hot oven produce something approaching magic. Baked until the top shatters into golden shards.

baked ham, Yukon Gold potatoes, broccoli, sharp cheddar, butter, flour, whole milk, Dijon mustard
Assemble the gratin before the IDP check-in and slide it into the oven after. One dish, no fuss, leftovers for lunch tomorrow.

AT THE TABLE

There's snow outside and warm gratin inside — total opposites. If you could design the perfect cozy day from the moment you wake up to the moment you fall asleep, what would every hour look like?

The contrast between a snowy 37°F day and a bubbling golden gratin creates a natural prompt for thinking about comfort and what makes a day feel good. Designing a full day hour-by-hour practices planning and sequencing — a cognitive skill blooming at 8.

The Comfort Trap

A few years ago, researchers noticed something strange about children raised in ultra-clean households. Kids who grew up with antibacterial everything — sanitized toys, sterilized surfaces, minimal outdoor play — developed allergies and autoimmune disorders at significantly higher rates than kids who played in dirt, had pets, and ate food off questionable surfaces. The hygiene hypothesis, as immunologists call it, reveals a paradox that Taleb would recognize instantly: the attempt to eliminate all risk created a new and worse risk. The immune system, deprived of the small stressors it needed to calibrate, turned on the body itself. Taleb calls this the problem of 'naive interventionism' — the belief that removing volatility makes a system safer when it often makes it catastrophically fragile. In **Antifragile** Ch. 7, he writes about how systems that are shielded from stressors lose their ability to handle them: 'Preventing small forest fires leads to a buildup of dry material that eventually results in a much larger conflagration.' The same pattern repeats everywhere. The parent who solves every problem for their child raises an adult who cannot solve problems. The manager who eliminates all friction from a team builds a team that shatters at the first real crisis.

This is the common mistake most of us make with transitions: we try to smooth them out. Snow in the forecast? Cancel everything. Kid nervous about a swim lesson? Maybe skip it this week. Feeling overwhelmed before a big work presentation? Retreat to what's comfortable. Each individual decision seems reasonable — even caring. But the cumulative effect is a life optimized for calm that cannot handle anything else. James Clear makes a complementary observation in **Atomic Habits** Ch. 2: 'Every action you take is a vote for the type of person you wish to become.' When you consistently vote for comfort, you're building an identity around avoidance. The antifragile move isn't to seek out suffering — that's just masochism with a philosophy degree. It's to stop reflexively eliminating the productive discomfort that makes you and your family stronger. The snow day isn't a disruption to your week. It's a rep. What productive discomfort did you avoid recently — and what did the avoidance actually cost you?

"Preventing small forest fires leads to a buildup of dry material that eventually results in a much larger conflagration."

— Nassim Nicholas Taleb, *Antifragile*, Ch. 7

Reflect: What productive discomfort did you avoid recently — and what did the avoidance actually cost you?

TASTE OF HOME · 8 SERVINGS · PREP 20 MIN · COOK 55 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Peel your potatoes, cut them into nice chunks, and get them boiling until they're just barely tender. You want them to hold their shape, not turn to mush. While they simmer, melt the butter in a big skillet, soften the onions, then stir in the flour and whisk in the milk until it thickens up and coats the back of a spoon. Toss in the cheddar and stir until it's silky smooth. Fold in the ham and blanched broccoli florets. Pour everything over those potatoes in a buttered baking dish, cover and bake at 350 for half an hour, then uncover and let the top get golden for another fifteen. This is the kind of dish that makes people think you spent all day cooking, so just smile and accept the compliment.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

Preheat oven to 350°F (175°C)

A · BOIL, THEN SIMMER 8-10 MIN UNTIL CRISP-TENDER, DRAIN

- 4 lbs Yukon Gold potatoes (*peeled, cut into 3/4-inch pieces*)
- water (*to cover*)

B · SAUTE ONION 5 MIN, ADD FLOUR, WHISK IN MILK, MELT CHEESE

- 1/4 cup butter
- 1 small onion (*chopped*)
- 1/4 cup all-purpose flour
- 2 cups whole milk
- 2 cups sharp cheddar (*shredded*)
- 1 tsp salt
- 1/2 tsp black pepper

C · FOLD INTO CHEESE SAUCE

- 2 cups baked ham (*cubed*)
- 2 cups broccoli florets (*blanched*)

Final: pour sauce over potatoes in greased 13x9 dish → cover, bake 25-30 min → uncover, bake 15-20 min until golden → rest 5 min

VARIATIONS

Croque Monsieur Potato Gratin — Swap cheddar for Gruyere and fold Dijon mustard into the bechamel for a French ... (recipe)

Ham and Cauliflower Low-Carb Gratin — Replace half the potatoes with cauliflower florets for a lighter, lower-carb version (recipe)

No-Dairy Ham and Potato Gratin — Swap the cheese sauce for herb-seasoned chicken broth thickened with mustard an... (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

SAUCE Infuse the béchamel properly — Before making your roux, simmer the milk for 10 minutes with a halved shallot, 2 crushed garlic cloves, a bay leaf, and 4 whole black peppercorns. Strain, then proceed with your butter-and-flour roux...

TEXTURE Panko-Parmigiano crunch top — Mix 1 cup panko breadcrumbs with 1/2 cup finely grated aged Parmigiano-Reggiano, 2 tablespoons melted butter, a pinch of smoked paprika, and a teaspoon of fresh thyme leaves. Scatter over the assembl...

PREPARATION Mandoline the potatoes, crisp the ham — Slice Yukon Golds on a mandoline to exactly 1/8-inch — no thicker, or you'll have crunchy spots. Before layering, cut the ham into 1/2-inch cubes and sear them in a dry skillet until the edges caramelize...

SURPRISE CHEF

Education & Recreation

2023 · INSTRUMENTAL FUNK / SOUL ·
CINEMATIC, GROOVY, WARM, NOSTALGIC

Melbourne's Surprise Chef recorded Education & Recreation (2022) in
what they call a creative vacuum — isolated from th...

*Cinematic instrumental soul for a cozy snow-day gratin — warm, unhurried, and
perfect for watching the flakes fall while the oven works.*

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Tuesday, March 3

6:00-6:30 PM | LEVEL 4 SWIM LESSONS

Still snowy at 40°F, but swim lessons wait for no weather. The trick tonight is timing: make the pasta dough before you leave, and it'll be rested and ready to roll the moment you walk back in the door.

Babo Pasta — Homemade Spinach Pasta with Alfredo Sauce

ITALIAN

The family's signature dish — handmade spinach pasta using only egg yolks for a rich, golden dough that practically glows on the plate. Tossed in a simple Alfredo of butter, Parmigiano-Reggiano, and starchy pasta water, with blanched broccoli florets folded in at the last second. Fresh pasta cooks in barely two minutes, so dinner comes together faster than you'd expect.

spinach, egg yolks, 00 flour, butter, Parmigiano-Reggiano, broccoli

Mix the dough before swim lessons, let it rest wrapped in plastic for 30 minutes. Roll and cut when you get home — Elsie loves cranking the pasta machine.

AT THE TABLE

We're making pasta from scratch tonight — the dough, the rolling, everything. What's something you've made completely from scratch that you're really proud of? It doesn't have to be food — it could be anything.

After swim lessons, she's physically tired but mentally open. Connecting the effort of handmade pasta to her own experiences of building something from nothing reinforces that effort has a taste — and it's satisfying. This also validates her growing sense of competence.

The Barbell

Most people manage risk the way they order at a restaurant they've never been to — they pick something in the middle. Not too adventurous, not too boring. A medium-risk portfolio. A moderately challenging goal. A career path that's neither too safe nor too bold. It feels responsible. Taleb thinks it's the worst possible strategy. In **Antifragile** Ch. 11, he introduces the barbell: 'I initially used the image of the barbell to describe a dual attitude of playing it safe in some areas and taking a lot of small risks in others, hence achieving antifragility.' The shape matters — heavy weights on both ends, nothing in the middle. In practice, this means being hyper-conservative where failure is catastrophic and hyper-aggressive where the downside is small but the upside is unlimited. Ninety percent of your savings in Treasury bills, ten percent in wild speculative bets. But the barbell isn't just about money. It's a decision architecture for everything. A Tuesday evening in your household might look like this: the non-negotiable conservative end is dinner together at the table, everyone present, phones away. That's the safe weight — the anchor that holds regardless of what kind of day anyone had. The aggressive end is what you do with that time. Try a recipe you've never attempted. Ask a question at dinner that nobody expects. Let the eight-year-old pick the album. If the recipe fails, you order pizza. If the conversation goes sideways, you learn something.

The middle — the thing the barbell eliminates — is the lukewarm default. The meal nobody chose because it was nobody's favorite. The evening spent in the same room but on separate screens, technically together but actually nowhere. Charlie Munger arrives at a similar conclusion from the opposite direction. In **Poor Charlie's Almanack**, he argues that 'the best way to get what you want is to deserve what you want' — which requires taking real swings, not hedging everything into mediocrity. The barbell gives you permission to protect what truly matters while experimenting freely with everything else. This week, as the weather itself swings from snow to spring, notice where you're defaulting to the middle. Where could you anchor one end firmly and let the other end surprise you? What would your Tuesday look like if you protected the essentials and freed everything else?

"I initially used the image of the barbell to describe a dual attitude of playing it safe in some areas and taking a lot of small risks in others, hence achieving antifragility."

— Nassim Nicholas Taleb, *Antifragile*, Ch. 11

Reflect: Where in your life are you defaulting to the comfortable middle — and what would it look like to anchor one end firmly while letting the other end surprise you?

FAMILY RECIPE (TECHNIQUE: BON APPETIT) · 4 SERVINGS · PREP 45 MIN · COOK 10 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Blanch the spinach for thirty seconds, squeeze out every last drop of water, and chop it fine. Make a well in your 00 flour, drop in the egg yolks, the spinach, and a drizzle of olive oil. Work it together with your hands until you've got a smooth, bright green ball of dough, then wrap it tight and let it rest for thirty minutes. Roll it thin through the pasta machine, dust it with flour, and cut your fettuccine. For the sauce, melt butter low and slow, pour in the cream, and stir in a mountain of freshly grated Parmigiano until it's thick and glossy. Cook your pasta in salty boiling water for just two minutes. If you're reaching for the jarred stuff, just close this book and order delivery.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

A · BLANCH 30 SEC, ICE BATH, SQUEEZE DRY, CHOP FINE

- 150g fresh spinach

B · MAKE WELL, ADD SPINACH + WET, KNEAD 8-10 MIN UNTIL SMOOTH

- 250g 00 flour
- 3 large egg yolks
- 1 tsp olive oil
- pinch salt

Final: wrap and rest 30 min → roll thin, dust with flour, cut fettuccine → cook 2 min in boiling salted water → toss with Alfredo sauce

VARIATIONS

Cacio e Pepe with Fresh Spinach Pasta — Skip the cream and toss the green pasta with pecorino, cracked black pepper, an... (recipe)

Brown Butter and Sage Spinach Fettuccine — Replace Alfredo with nutty browned butter, crispy fried sage leaves, and a show... (recipe)

Lemon Ricotta Spinach Pasta — Toss fresh pasta with ricotta, lemon zest, toasted pine nuts, and a splash of p... (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

SAUCE True Alfredo — emulsify, don't cook — Melt 4 tablespoons of unsalted butter in a wide skillet over medium-low heat. Add the hot, just-drained pasta directly into the butter with 1/2 cup of starchy pasta water. Toss vigorously. Kill the h...

TEXTURE Toasted garlic breadcrumb gremolata — In a small skillet, warm 2 tablespoons of good olive oil over medium heat. Add 3 cloves of thinly sliced garlic and cook until just golden — 90 seconds, no more. Add 1/2 cup coarse fresh breadcrumbs ...

PREPARATION Rest and hydrate the pasta dough — After mixing the spinach pasta dough, wrap it tightly in plastic and rest at room temperature for a full 30 minutes. The gluten relaxes, making it easier to roll thin without tearing. When rolling, g...

K O K O R O K O

Could We Be More

2022 · AFROBEAT / JAZZ · WARM, HOPEFUL,
BREEZY, SOULFUL

London's eight-piece Kokoroko spent years refining Could We Be More
(2022) after their breakout single "Abusey Junction...

*Gentle, hopeful Afrobeat-jazz for a post-swim wind-down with homemade pasta —
rhythmic enough to keep energy up, warm enough to settle a tired Tuesday.*

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Wednesday, March 4

PRODUCT DAY

The temperature jumps to 62°F with a light drizzle — spring is knocking.

Product Day means a long stretch at work, so dinner needs to be fast,

satisfying, and mostly hands-off once the wok gets hot.

Beef & Broccoli Stir Fry with Oyster Mushrooms

CHINESE

A Chinese-American classic that dates to the 1920s, when Cantonese immigrants swapped hard-to-find gai lan for Western broccoli and created something entirely new. Velveting flank steak wok-seared at screaming heat with broccoli and oyster mushrooms, glazed in a sauce of oyster sauce, soy, garlic, ginger, and Shaoxing wine. Thirty minutes, start to plate.

flank steak, broccoli, oyster mushrooms, garlic, ginger, green onions, oyster sauce, Shaoxing wine

Velvet the beef in a cornstarch slurry for 15 minutes before cooking — this is the secret to takeout-tender strips at home.

AT THE TABLE

Stir fry cooks really fast — everything happens in just a few minutes over high heat. What's something important that you think people rush through too quickly? What would happen if everyone just slowed down?

Dan's Product Day means the household tempo might feel faster than usual. This question invites Elsie to reflect on pace and presence — a concept she's just beginning to grasp at 8. It quietly validates the idea that slowing down is wise, not lazy, and gives her permission to name what she notices about the world around her.

Pressure Shared Is Pressure Halved

It's Wednesday — Product Day — and one of you walks through the door tonight carrying the invisible weight of a day spent performing. Presenting, defending decisions, reading the room, managing up. The other has been managing a different kind of pressure: the household logistics, the emotional labor of keeping an eight-year-old on track through homework and dinner and the low-grade chaos of a school week. Both of you are tired. Neither of you knows exactly what the other's day cost. This is the moment where most couples get it wrong. The default move is to retreat — to decompress alone, scroll the phone, give each other space because it seems kind. But Brené Brown argues that this well-intentioned withdrawal is actually the fragile response. In **Daring Greatly** Ch. 1, she writes: 'Vulnerability is not winning or losing; it's having the courage to show up and be seen when we have no control over the outcome.' The antifragile move in a relationship isn't to shield your partner from your stress. It's to let them see it — imperfectly, without a polished narrative — and to ask to see theirs in return. Taleb's framework maps onto this cleanly. A relationship where both people perform composure is a candle — beautiful and calm until the real wind hits. A relationship where both people practice naming what's hard becomes fire.

This doesn't mean dumping your work frustrations onto someone who's already running on fumes. It means something smaller and harder: a specific, honest sentence. 'Today was rougher than I expected. Can I just sit near you for a minute?' That's not weakness. That's load-bearing vulnerability — the kind that makes the structure stronger each time you practice it. The same principle applies at the dinner table with your kid. An eight-year-old doesn't need you to be perfect. She needs you to be real at a scale she can understand. 'Dad had a hard meeting today. You know what helped? Taking three deep breaths before I walked back in.' You've just modeled antifragility in thirty seconds — the idea that difficulty isn't something to hide from but something you can move through and name. Tonight, after Product Day, after swim lessons, after whatever the week has thrown: who in your household is carrying pressure they haven't named yet, and what would it take to make space for them to say it?

"Vulnerability is not winning or losing; it's having the courage to show up and be seen when we have no control over the outcome."

— Brené Brown, *Daring Greatly*, Ch. 1

Reflect: Who in your household is carrying pressure they haven't named yet — and what would it take to make space for them to say it?

SERIOUS EATS · 4 SERVINGS · PREP 20 MIN · COOK 15 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Slice the flank steak thin against the grain and toss it with soy sauce, Shaoxing wine, and cornstarch. Let it sit while you mix the sauce: oyster sauce, soy, a little sugar, chicken stock, and cornstarch. Blanch the broccoli for thirty seconds until it turns that electric green, then shock it in ice water and drain it dry. Get your wok screaming hot, sear the beef in batches until it's got color but still pink inside, and set it aside. Same wok, hit the garlic and ginger for thirty seconds, add the broccoli and oyster mushrooms, and toss them fast. Pour in the sauce, return the beef, and stir until everything is coated in a sticky, glossy glaze. Serve it over rice immediately because nobody in the history of cooking has ever been sorry for eating this hot.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

A · TOSS TOGETHER, MARINATE 15-30 MIN

- 1 lb flank steak (*sliced thin against the grain*)
- 2 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tbsp Shaoxing wine
- 1 tbsp cornstarch

B · WHISK TOGETHER, SET ASIDE

- 3 tbsp oyster sauce
- 2 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tsp sugar
- 1/2 cup chicken stock
- 1 tbsp cornstarch
- 1 tsp sesame oil

C · BLANCH BROCCOLI 30 SEC, ICE BATH; STIR-FRY AROMATICS 30 SEC

- 1 lb broccoli florets
- 6 oz oyster mushrooms (*torn into pieces*)
- 4 cloves garlic (*minced*)
- 1-inch piece fresh ginger (*minced*)
- 3 tbsp vegetable oil (*divided*)

Final: sear beef in batches over high heat (remove) → wok-fry garlic, ginger, broccoli, mushrooms 1 min → return beef, pour sauce, toss until glazed → serve over steamed rice

VARIATIONS

Black Bean Sauce Beef and Broccoli — Swap oyster sauce for fermented black bean sauce and use broccoli for a more ... (recipe)

Beef and Broccoli Noodle Stir Fry — Skip the rice and toss everything with chewy udon noodles and a splash of hoisi... (recipe)

Crispy Ginger Tofu and Broccoli Stir Fry — Replace beef with pressed, cornstarch-dusted tofu fried until shatteringly cris... (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

MARINADE Velvet the flank steak — Slice flank steak thin against the grain. Toss with 1 tablespoon soy sauce, 1 tablespoon cornstarch, 1/2 teaspoon baking soda, 1 tablespoon Shaoxing wine, and 1 teaspoon neutral oil. Let it sit for 2...

PREPARATION Blanch the broccoli, char the mushrooms — Blanch broccoli florets in boiling salted water for exactly 60 seconds, then plunge into ice water. Drain and pat dry. For the oyster mushrooms: tear them into large pieces (don't cut — torn edges se...

SAUCE Glossy Shaoxing-sesame finishing sauce — Mix 2 tablespoons oyster sauce, 1 tablespoon soy sauce, 1 tablespoon Shaoxing wine, 1 teaspoon dark soy sauce (for color), 1 teaspoon sugar, and 1 teaspoon cornstarch dissolved in 2 tablespoons water...

THE BUDOS BAND

Long in the Tooth

2020 · AFROBEAT / FUNK · INTENSE,
DRIVING, PSYCHEDELIC, POWERFUL

Staten Island's Budos Band recorded Long in the Tooth (2020) at
Diamond Mine Studios in Queens to mark their 15th anniv...

*The driving energy of Afrobeat-funk matches the fast pace of wok cooking — high
heat, quick moves, thunderous results after a long Product Day.*

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Thursday, March 5

Seventy-three degrees and the windows are finally open — the first real spring evening of the year. This is the night for something light, casual, and fun to make together.

Broccoli & Oyster Mushroom Flatbread with Ricotta & Chili Honey

ITALIAN-AMERICAN

A modern riff on Italian pizza bianca meets the Brooklyn hot-honey trend: pizza dough stretched thin and topped with dollops of ricotta, roasted broccoli florets, sautéed oyster mushrooms, red pepper flakes, and a drizzle of chili honey that caramelizes in the oven. The sweet-spicy-creamy combination is addictive, and the flat format makes it perfect for little hands to help assemble.

pizza dough, ricotta, broccoli, oyster mushrooms, mozzarella, hot honey, red pepper flakes, olive oil
Get Elsie involved in topping the flatbread — spreading ricotta and drizzling honey is the fun part. Use store-bought dough for speed.

AT THE TABLE

It's the first really warm evening of the year — 73 degrees! What's something about spring that you're most excited about? And what's one thing about winter you'll actually miss?

Holding two feelings at once — excitement for what's coming and a little sadness for what's leaving — is an emotional complexity milestone at age 8. The warm evening and the hands-on fun of making flatbread together create a relaxed, open setting to practice it.

Subtract Before You Add

You're staring at a Thursday that already feels overscheduled. The reflexive move is to add — add a plan, add a system, add an app, add a reminder. We are relentless adders. When a relationship feels distant, we add a date night. When work feels chaotic, we add a productivity tool. When our kid seems restless, we add an activity. But Taleb's most counterintuitive principle is *via negativa* — the idea that the most powerful improvements come from removing things, not adding them. In **Antifragile** Book VI, Ch. 21, he writes: 'In medicine, as elsewhere, *via negativa* — removal of drugs, salt, sugar, bread, or even doctors — is vastly more potent than *via positiva*.' The healthiest thing you can do for your body isn't to add a supplement. It's to remove the processed food. The most effective thing you can do for your Thursday isn't to add another commitment. It's to cancel one. This runs against every instinct we have as modern parents and professionals. Productivity culture tells us that more is more — more structured activities, more enrichment, more optimization. But look at the week you're living right now. Snow on Monday meant canceled plans, forced stillness, unexpected time together. And if you're honest, some of that unplanned time was the best part of the week.

Charlie Munger arrives at the same destination through inversion: 'It is remarkable how much long-term advantage people like us have gotten by trying to be consistently not stupid, instead of trying to be very intelligent' (**Poor Charlie's Almanack**, Lecture on the Psychology of Human Misjudgment). Instead of asking 'what should I add to make this week better?' ask 'what should I remove?' The answer might be an obligation that nobody actually wants. A screen-time habit that's eating into conversation. A recurring commitment that made sense six months ago but now just generates logistical friction. *Via negativa* is especially powerful during transitions because transitions already feel like too much. Spring cleaning isn't just about closets — it's about calendars, routines, and assumptions that served you in winter but are now dead weight. Tonight, with the temperature climbing toward seventy-three degrees and the windows finally open, try this: name one thing in your family's weekly routine that you could simply stop doing. Not replace. Not improve. Just stop. What disappears if you let it go — and what grows in the space it leaves behind?

"Via negativa — removal of drugs, salt, sugar, bread, or even doctors — is vastly more potent than via positiva."

— Nassim Nicholas Taleb, *Antifragile*, Book VI, Ch. 21

Reflect: What is one thing in your family's weekly routine that you could simply stop doing — and what might grow in the space it leaves behind?

FOOD52 · 4 SERVINGS · PREP 15 MIN · COOK 20 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Heat your oven to 450 and get that pizza stone hot if you've got one. Toss the broccoli florets and sliced oyster mushrooms with olive oil, salt, and a pinch of red pepper, then roast them until they're charred and sweet at the edges. Mix the ricotta with lemon zest, a clove of grated garlic, salt, and pepper until it's smooth and spreadable. Stretch your dough thin, spread the ricotta all over, and scatter the charred vegetables on top. Bake until the crust is golden and puffed, about ten minutes. Pull it out and drizzle the hot honey all over while it's still steaming. This is not diet food and it was never trying to be.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

Preheat oven to 450°F (230°C) with pizza stone

A · TOSS, ROAST 425F 15 MIN UNTIL CHARRED AT EDGES

- 2 heads broccoli (*cut into small florets*)
- 6 oz oyster mushrooms (*sliced*)
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 1/2 tsp salt
- pinch red pepper flakes

B · STIR UNTIL SMOOTH AND SPREADABLE

- 1 cup whole-milk ricotta
- 1 lemon (*zested*)
- 1 clove garlic (*grated*)
- to taste salt and pepper

C · WARM GENTLY, WHISK TOGETHER

- 3 tbsp honey
- 1 tsp crushed red pepper
- 1 tsp apple cider vinegar

Final: stretch 1 lb pizza dough thin → spread ricotta, top with roasted vegetables → bake 10 min until crust is golden → drizzle chili honey, slice, serve

VARIATIONS

Broccoli Pesto and Burrata Flatbread — Blend half the broccoli into a pesto with basil, garlic, and pine nuts, then to... (recipe)

Mediterranean Broccoli Flatbread with Olives and Feta — Add kalamata olives and crumbled feta instead of ricotta, finish with lemon jui... (recipe)

Smitten Kitchen Broccoli Pizza — Use a thin, crispy crust with mozzarella and roasted lemon-pepper broccoli for ... (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Whip the ricotta, roast the toppings — Whip the ricotta in a food processor with a tablespoon of good olive oil, the zest of one lemon, a pinch of salt, and a crack of black pepper until cloud-smooth — about 45 seconds. Separately, toss b...

SAUCE Make your own chili honey — Warm 1/4 cup honey in a small saucepan over low heat with 1 teaspoon red pepper flakes and 1 teaspoon apple cider vinegar. Let it steep for 5 minutes off the heat. The vinegar is the secret — it cuts...

ACID Fresh arugula and lemon finish — The second the flatbread comes out of the oven, pile a handful of baby arugula on top and squeeze half a lemon over it. The residual heat barely wilts the greens. Finish with a thread of your best ol...

NUBIYAN TWIST

Freedom Fables

2021 · AFROBEAT / JAZZ / FUNK · JOYFUL,
ENERGETIC, CELEBRATORY, DIVERSE

UK collective Nubiyán Twist spent five years building Freedom Fables
(2021) on the road, refining tracks through live j...

*Joyful, celebratory energy for the first spring evening with the windows open — a
soundtrack for making flatbread with warm air flowing through the kitchen.*

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Friday, March 6

4:30-6:00 PM | ELSIE YAT

Friday at 59°F with Elsie at YAT until six. A quieter evening calls for something elegant and quick — the kind of meal that looks impressive but takes twenty-five minutes from fridge to table.

Pan-Seared Branzino with Lemon-Herb Butter & Roasted Broccoli

MEDITERRANEAN

Skin-on branzino fillets seared in a cast-iron pan until the skin crackles like a chip, finished with a sauce of brown butter, lemon, capers, and fresh herbs. Branzino — a Mediterranean sea bass prized for its mild, sweet flesh — needs almost nothing beyond high heat, good butter, and restraint. Served alongside simple roasted broccoli with lemon zest and flaky salt.

branzino fillets, butter, lemon, capers, fresh parsley, broccoli, olive oil

Pat the fillets bone-dry with paper towels before they hit the pan — wet skin steams instead of crisping. Dad's fish craving, answered.

 *Elsie's not a fan of fish this week — have buttered pasta or a quesadilla ready as her backup, plus the roasted broccoli she loves.*

AT THE TABLE

Tonight's dinner is fish, and we know that's not your favorite. But here's a question: what's something you used to not like — a food, an activity, a song, even a person — that you've totally changed your mind about? What made you change?

This reframes the fish dinner from a dreaded meal into a growth conversation. At 8, kids are starting to notice that their preferences shift over time, which is a building block for understanding that identity isn't fixed — you're allowed to change your mind about things, including yourself. No pressure to eat the fish — just to think about change.

The Case for Shelter

All week we've been building the case for antifragility — for seeking productive stress, embracing volatility, and treating disruption as fertilizer. But here's the strongest argument against it, and it deserves a hearing: some things should be protected. Not everything benefits from being roughed up. A child's sense of safety doesn't get stronger through unpredictability — it gets stronger through consistency. A marriage doesn't deepen through constant turbulence — it deepens through reliable presence. Your eight-year-old doesn't need every Friday to be an adventure in resilience. Sometimes she needs the same bedtime routine, the same story, the same parent in the same chair saying the same goodnight. Taleb himself acknowledges this in **Antifragile** Ch. 4: 'Parts of the system must be fragile to make the entire system antifragile.' The restaurant industry is antifragile because individual restaurants fail — but you wouldn't tell the owner of a closing restaurant that her pain is good for the ecosystem. At the human scale, the people inside the system need protection even when the system around them benefits from stress.

This is where James Clear's identity framework provides the necessary counterweight. In **Atomic Habits** Ch. 2, he writes: 'Every action you take is a vote for the type of person you wish to become.' The goal isn't to make everything in your life antifragile. The goal is to be deliberate about which parts you expose to volatility and which parts you shelter. Your child's emotional safety: shelter it. Your own willingness to try a new approach at work: expose it. Friday-night family rituals: shelter them. Saturday's plans: expose them to spontaneity. The barbell returns — heavy protection on one end, open experimentation on the other. The mistake isn't in seeking comfort. The mistake is in seeking only comfort, or in applying toughness where tenderness is what's actually needed. The strongest families aren't the ones that weather every storm without flinching. They're the ones that know which storms to walk through and which ones to close the door against. As your Friday winds down tonight — YAT rehearsal done, the weekend opening up — ask yourself: what in your family life deserves to be protected from disruption this week, and are you protecting it fiercely enough?

"Every action you take is a vote for the type of person you wish to become."

— James Clear, *Atomic Habits*, Ch. 2

Reflect: What in your family life deserves to be fiercely protected from disruption — and are you protecting it enough?

FOOD & WINE · 4 SERVINGS · PREP 10 MIN · COOK 20 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Pat the branzino fillets bone dry with paper towels, both sides. Season with salt and pepper, nothing fancy. Get your pan hot with a little olive oil, then lay the fillets in skin side down and press them flat with a spatula for the first minute so the skin crisps evenly. Don't touch them for three minutes until the skin is golden and crunchy. Flip gently, cook another two minutes, then take them out. In the same pan, drop in the butter, let it foam and turn just barely golden, then add capers, lemon juice, and a handful of fresh herbs. Spoon that sizzling butter over the fish and serve it next to your roasted broccoli. See? Ten minutes and you've got a restaurant plate.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

A · SEASON, SEAR SKIN-SIDE DOWN 3 MIN, FLIP 2 MIN (REMOVE)

- 4 branzino fillets (*patted very dry*)
- to taste salt and pepper
- 2 tbsp olive oil

B · FOAM BUTTER UNTIL GOLDEN, ADD CAPERS AND LEMON, SWIRL IN HERBS

- 4 tbsp unsalted butter
- 2 tbsp capers (*drained*)
- 2 tbsp lemon juice
- 1 tsp lemon zest
- 2 tbsp fresh parsley (*chopped*)
- 1 tsp fresh thyme (*leaves*)

Final: spoon butter sauce over fish → serve alongside roasted broccoli

VARIATIONS

Branzino with White Wine and Cherry Tomatoes — Deglaze the pan with white wine, add burst cherry tomatoes and olives for a Med... (recipe)

Whole Roasted Branzino with Herbs and Lemon — Stuff whole fish with lemon slices, rosemary, and thyme, then roast at 425F for... (recipe)

Branzino with Almond Brown Butter — Toast slivered almonds in the brown butter alongside the capers for a nutty, cr... (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Achieve glass-crispy skin — Pat the fillets aggressively dry with paper towels — both sides, twice. Score the skin with 3 shallow diagonal cuts to prevent curling. Season the skin side with salt 5 minutes before cooking to draw...

SAUCE Brown butter with fried capers — After removing the fish, wipe the skillet and add 3 tablespoons unsalted butter over medium heat. Once it foams, add 2 tablespoons drained capers — they'll sputter and pop, then turn into crispy litt...

TEMPERATURE Cold herb salsa verde on the side — Finely chop a generous handful of fresh parsley, a few mint leaves, and a small shallot. Combine with 1 minced garlic clove, 1 tablespoon red wine vinegar, 3 tablespoons good olive oil, and a pinch o...

MARCOS VALLE

Garra

1971 · BRAZILIAN / MPB / FUNK · BREEZY,
RHYTHMIC, SOPHISTICATED, SUNNY

Marcos Valle recorded Garra (1971) at Odeon Studios in Rio de Janeiro during Brazil's military dictatorship, weaving su...

Breezy Brazilian grooves for a Mediterranean fish dinner — the ocean vibes of Garra complement branzino perfectly, and the rhythm keeps Friday evening light.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Saturday, March 7

Saturday hits 73°F again — grilling weather, no question. The pork butt goes on in the morning, and by evening the whole neighborhood knows what's happening in your backyard.

BBQ Pork Butt with Broccoli Slaw

AMERICAN BBQ

Low-and-slow American barbecue at its finest: a pork butt rubbed with smoked paprika, brown sugar, mustard powder, and black pepper, cooked for hours until it falls apart at the touch of a fork. The tradition stretches back to colonial Southern pit cooks who transformed tough shoulder cuts into something transcendent through patience and smoke. Piled on brioche buns with a crunchy broccoli slaw made from all those stems you've been saving.

pork butt, smoked paprika, brown sugar, broccoli stems, cabbage, apple cider vinegar, brioche buns

Start the pork butt by 9 AM for a 6 PM dinner. The broccoli slaw uses stems from the week — zero waste, maximum crunch.

AT THE TABLE

This pork has been cooking since this morning — hours and hours of slow heat and patience. If you had to spend a whole day doing just one thing, but with someone you've never done it with before, what would you pick and who would you invite?

The slow cook of BBQ mirrors patience and anticipation — the best things take time. Asking her to imagine crossing a social boundary (doing something with an unexpected person) exercises perspective-taking and social imagination, both growing fast at this age. The warm Saturday and outdoor BBQ energy make this feel expansive, not interrogative.

The Garden After Snow

Walk outside this morning. It's going to be seventy-three degrees — forty degrees warmer than Monday's snow. The crocuses are pushing through. The Bradford pears along the Reston paths are starting to bud. If you look closely at the soil where the snow sat three days ago, you'll see it — the ground is softer, more saturated, more ready to grow than it was before the storm. This is not a metaphor someone invented. This is literally how spring works. The freeze-thaw cycle breaks up compacted soil, allowing roots to penetrate deeper. The snow itself is called 'poor man's fertilizer' because it captures atmospheric nitrogen and delivers it directly to the earth as it melts. The cold period triggers vernalization in perennial plants — a biological requirement for the stress of winter before they can bloom. The trees that sway in March wind grow thicker trunks. The garden after snow is not the garden despite snow. It is the garden because of snow. Taleb captured this in his most vivid image: 'Wind extinguishes a candle and energizes fire' (*Antifragile*, Ch. 2). On Sunday, we asked you to consider whether your life was set up as a candle or a fire. Six days later, you've explored the shape of that question from every angle — the comfort trap, the barbell, the power of subtraction, the necessity of shelter.

Here's what it comes down to. You don't get to control whether the week brings snow or sunshine, Product Days or pajama days, breakthroughs or breakdowns. What you get to control is what kind of system you are — one that needs perfect conditions to function, or one that has learned to convert imperfect conditions into growth. The risk with any week of principles is that they become another thing you read and forget. Taleb would call that the 'tourist' approach to ideas — visiting them briefly without any skin in the game. So here's a concrete move: pick one thing from this week that actually landed. Maybe it was the barbell. Maybe via negativa. Maybe it was just the permission to stop smoothing out every rough edge for your kid. Whatever it was, do one thing differently because of it — not next month, not next quarter, today. The spring doesn't wait for permission. The crocus doesn't file a plan. It pushes through because the season changed and it was ready. What's one thing you'll do differently today — not next week, not someday — because the season has changed and you're ready?

"Wind extinguishes a candle and energizes fire."

— Nassim Nicholas Taleb, *Antifragile*, Ch. 2

Reflect: What's one thing you'll do differently today — not next week, not someday — because the season has changed and you're ready?

The crocus doesn't wait for perfect conditions. It pushes through because the cold made it ready — and so did you.

SERIOUS EATS · 8-10 SERVINGS · PREP 30 MIN + OVERNIGHT · COOK 10-14 HOURS

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Mix your rub the night before: brown sugar, smoked paprika, black pepper, garlic powder, onion powder, mustard powder, and a good amount of kosher salt. Rub the pork butt all over, every crevice, and let it sit uncovered in the fridge overnight so the surface dries out and the flavors sink in. Set up your smoker at 225, add your wood chunks, and put the meat on fat side up. This is a patience game. You're looking at ten to twelve hours until it hits 200 degrees inside and the bone wiggles loose. Pull it out, wrap it in foil, let it rest for an hour, then shred it with two forks. For the slaw, shave the broccoli stems and toss them with shredded cabbage, vinegar, a little sugar, and mayo. The people who tell you barbecue shouldn't take all day have never made anything worth eating.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

Preheat oven to Smoker to 225°F (107°C)

A · MIX TOGETHER THOROUGHLY

- 1/4 cup brown sugar (*packed*)
- 1/4 cup smoked paprika
- 1 tbsp black pepper
- 1 tbsp garlic powder
- 1 tbsp onion powder
- 2 tsp mustard powder
- 2 tbsp kosher salt
- 1 tsp cayenne pepper

B · COAT WITH MUSTARD, APPLY RUB, REFRIGERATE UNCOVERED OVERNIGHT

- 6-8 lb bone-in pork butt (*trimmed*)
- 2 tbsp yellow mustard

Final: smoke fat-side up at 225F for 10-12 hrs → target 200-205F internal temp → wrap in foil, rest 1 hr → shred with two forks, toss with juices

VARIATIONS

Coffee-Rubbed Pulled Pork — Add finely ground espresso to the spice rub for a deep, smoky bitterness that b... (recipe)

Asian-Style Pulled Pork Bao Buns — Marinate with soy, ginger, and five-spice, then serve shredded pork in steamed ... (recipe)

Carolina Vinegar-Sauce Pulled Pork — Skip the sweet sauce and serve with a sharp cider vinegar and red pepper flake ... (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

MARINADE Dry brine overnight, rub in the morning — The night before, coat the pork butt generously with kosher salt — about 1 tablespoon per 5 pounds. Let it sit uncovered in the fridge on a wire rack for 12-24 hours. The salt penetrates deep, season...

PREPARATION Apple cider vinegar spritz and the stall — Smoke at 225-250°F with a mix of hickory and apple wood. Every 45 minutes after the first 2 hours, spritz the surface with a 50/50 mix of apple cider vinegar and apple juice using a spray bottle. Whe...

ACID Upgrade the broccoli slaw with mustard vinaigrette — Shred broccoli stems on a box grater or mandoline. Toss with shredded green cabbage, shredded carrots, and thinly sliced scallions. For the dressing: whisk 3 tablespoons apple cider vinegar, 1 tables...

CURTIS MAYFIELD

Superfly

1972 · SOUL / FUNK · GROOVY, CINEMATIC,
SOULFUL, POWERFUL

Curtis Mayfield wrote, produced, and performed Superfly (1972) as a pointed counternarrative to the blaxploitation film...

The ultimate BBQ soundtrack — Curtis Mayfield's funky, socially conscious soul is exactly what a warm Saturday pork butt cook demands. Turn it up and tend the fire.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Kitchen & Pantry

Appetizers, salads, and beverages

Appetizers

Charred Broccoli with Whipped Feta, Lemon & Chili Oil

Broccoli florets roasted at 450°F until deeply charred and crispy at the edges, served over a swipe of whipped feta blended with lemon zest and a drizzle of homemade chili oil. Scattered with toasted sesame seeds and flaky salt.

broccoli, feta cheese, lemon, chili flakes, sesame seeds, olive oil, garlic

Stuffed Cremini Mushrooms with Parmesan, Herbs & Green Onions

Large cremini mushroom caps filled with a mixture of their own diced stems, Parmesan, breadcrumbs, garlic, green onions, and fresh parsley, then baked until golden and bubbling.

cremini mushrooms, Parmesan, breadcrumbs, garlic, green onions, fresh parsley, olive oil

Salads

COMPOSED DINNER

Roasted Broccoli, Blood Orange & Burrata Salad

A composed arrangement of warm roasted broccoli florets, blood orange segments, torn burrata, toasted hazelnuts, and shaved Pecorino.

Dressing: Blood orange vinaigrette: fresh blood orange juice, white wine vinegar, Dijon mustard, extra-virgin olive oil, minced shallot, honey, flaky salt, cracked black pepper

The char on roasted broccoli provides nutty bitterness that blood orange tames with tart sweetness. Burrata adds lush creaminess. Italian amaro-dolce principles at work.

TOSSED DINNER

Chopped Broccoli, Kale & Apple Salad with Cheddar Croutons

Finely chopped raw broccoli, massaged lacinato kale, crisp Honeycrisp apple matchsticks, toasted sunflower seeds, dried cranberries, and sharp cheddar croutons.

Dressing: Apple cider vinaigrette: apple cider vinegar, Dijon mustard, maple syrup, extra-virgin olive oil, minced shallot, salt, black pepper

Raw broccoli crunch pairs with tender massaged kale. Apple sweetness and cranberry tartness play against sharp cheddar croutons. Maple-mustard vinaigrette unifies with autumnal warmth.

SIDE

Asian Broccoli Slaw with Sesame-Ginger Dressing

Shredded broccoli stems and florets, shaved carrots, red cabbage, and edamame tossed in a bright sesame-ginger dressing. Topped with crispy wonton strips.

Dressing: Sesame-ginger dressing: toasted sesame oil, rice vinegar, fresh grated ginger, soy sauce, honey, neutral oil, lime juice, garlic, salt

Beverage Pairings

Willamette Valley Pinot Noir

Bright, medium-bodied Pinot Noir with cherry, cranberry, and forest floor notes. Enough acidity to cut through creamy stroganoff, enough fruit to complement grilled pork.

Versatile red that works across the week's diverse proteins.

Weihenstephaner Hefeweizen

The world's oldest brewery's flagship wheat beer — hazy gold with banana, clove, and bread crust aromas. Effervescent and refreshing.

Classic pairing for BBQ and grilled meats. The 73°F grilling weather demands a cold Hefe.

Cucumber-Mint Agua Fresca with Lime

English cucumber, fresh mint, lime juice, and a touch of agave blended with cold water and strained. Light, herbal, and impossibly refreshing.

Non-alcoholic option the whole family can enjoy. Elsie's drink of the week.

Family Corner

Conversation starters, parenting nudges, and connection ideas

Parenting Corner

Same Roots, New Blooms

The week starts in winter and ends in spring — snow on Monday, 73°F by Thursday — and Elsie is doing the same thing. She's the same girl who shows up in the pool on Tuesday, at the stir fry table on Wednesday, and rolling flatbread dough on Thursday, but each setting reveals a different petal. Broccoli appears in three wildly different dinners this week — gratin, stir fry, flatbread — and that's exactly how growth works. You don't become someone new. You bloom where you're already planted. This week, notice the ways she's stretching into new shapes of herself while staying rooted in the family that holds her.

Dinner Conversation Starters

SUNDAY — BEEF & MUSHROOM STROGANOFF

"Stroganoff is a dish people have been making for hundreds of years in Russia. If our family had one recipe we'd pass down for a hundred years, what should it be — and what story would we tell about why it's special?"

At 8, Elsie is beginning to understand legacy and tradition. Connecting food to family identity helps her see herself as part of a longer story, not just a kid eating dinner. Sunday's unhurried pace makes room for this kind of big-picture thinking.

MONDAY — BAKED HAM, BROCCOLI & POTATO GRATIN

"There's snow outside and warm gratin inside — total opposites. If you could design the perfect cozy day from the moment you wake up to the moment you fall asleep, what would every hour look like?"

The contrast between a snowy 37°F day and a bubbling golden gratin creates a natural prompt for thinking about comfort and what makes a day feel good. Designing a full day hour-by-hour practices planning and sequencing — a cognitive skill blooming at 8.

TUESDAY — BABO PASTA (HOMEMADE SPINACH PASTA)

"We're making pasta from scratch tonight — the dough, the rolling, everything. What's something you've made completely from scratch that you're really proud of? It doesn't have to be food — it could be anything."

After swim lessons, she's physically tired but mentally open. Connecting the effort of handmade pasta to her own experiences of building something from nothing reinforces that effort has a taste — and it's satisfying. This also validates her growing sense of competence.

WEDNESDAY — BEEF & BROCCOLI STIR FRY

"Stir fry cooks really fast — everything happens in just a few minutes over high heat. What's something important that you think people rush through too quickly? What would happen if everyone just slowed down?"

Dan's Product Day means the household tempo might feel faster than usual. This question invites Elsie to reflect on pace and presence — a concept she's just beginning to grasp at 8. It quietly validates the idea that slowing down is wise, not lazy, and gives her permission to name what she notices about the world around her.

Conversation Starters (continued)

THURSDAY — BROCCOLI & OYSTER MUSHROOM FLATBREAD

"It's the first really warm evening of the year — 73 degrees! What's something about spring that you're most excited about? And what's one thing about winter you'll actually miss?"

Holding two feelings at once — excitement for what's coming and a little sadness for what's leaving — is an emotional complexity milestone at age 8. The warm evening and the hands-on fun of making flatbread together create a relaxed, open setting to practice it.

FRIDAY — PAN-SEARED BRANZINO

"Tonight's dinner is fish, and we know that's not your favorite. But here's a question: what's something you used to not like — a food, an activity, a song, even a person — that you've totally changed your mind about? What made you change?"

This reframes the fish dinner from a dreaded meal into a growth conversation. At 8, kids are starting to notice that their preferences shift over time, which is a building block for understanding that identity isn't fixed — you're allowed to change your mind about things, including yourself. No pressure to eat the fish — just to think about change.

SATURDAY — BBQ PORK BUTT

"This pork has been cooking since this morning — hours and hours of slow heat and patience. If you had to spend a whole day doing just one thing, but with someone you've never done it with before, what would you pick and who would you invite?"

The slow cook of BBQ mirrors patience and anticipation — the best things take time. Asking her to imagine crossing a social boundary (doing something with an unexpected person) exercises perspective-taking and social imagination, both growing fast at this age. The warm Saturday and outdoor BBQ energy make this feel expansive, not interrogative.

Nudges

The Broccoli Critic

Broccoli appears in three dinners this week in three completely different forms — golden gratin on Monday, quick-fire stir fry on Wednesday, and roasted on flatbread Thursday. That's a rare and playful opportunity. Turn Elsie into the family's official broccoli judge. She rates each broccoli dish on a scale of 1-10 and explains her reasoning — texture, flavor, how it looks on the plate. By Thursday she's a food critic with opinions and evidence, which is actually a structured exercise in evaluating, comparing, and articulating preferences. Eight-year-olds love having expertise, and this gives her a role at the table that's genuinely hers.

1. Monday night, announce it casually: 'Broccoli shows up three times this week in three different outfits. You're our official broccoli judge.'
 2. After each broccoli dinner, she rates and explains. Write her scores on a sticky note on the fridge.
 3. Thursday night, reveal the winner — 'The Broccoli Champion of the week is...' Let her present her verdict like a real critic.
-

The Spring Door

Thursday is the first warm evening of the year — 73°F after days of snow and cold. For Elsie, the shift from winter on Monday to shorts-weather on Thursday is dramatic and worth marking as a family. After flatbread dinner on Thursday, go outside together. Sit on the porch, walk around the block, or just stand in the yard and breathe. Don't structure it — just be outside in the warmth as a family. Say something simple: 'Winter's behind us. Let's go say hello to spring.' Marking seasonal transitions teaches Elsie to notice the world changing around her, which builds the kind of attentiveness that feeds empathy, wonder, and presence.

1. After dinner Thursday, say: 'It's too nice to be inside. Shoes on — let's go.'
 2. Walk slowly. Point out what's changing — buds on trees, birds you haven't heard in months, the longer daylight.
 3. Ask one question: 'What does spring smell like to you?' Then just listen.
-

The Fish Heads-Up

Elsie doesn't like fish, and Friday's branzino is on the menu. Surprising an 8-year-old with a food she dislikes erodes trust. Preparing her in advance shows respect for her preferences while modeling openness. Bring it up Wednesday or Thursday, casually — not as a lecture, but a respectful heads-up: 'Friday's dinner is fish. I know that's not your favorite. Here's the deal: there'll be plenty on the table that you love, but I'd be proud of you if you tried one bite. If you don't like it, totally fine.' The conversation before the meal matters more than the meal itself. It teaches her that her voice is heard AND that being open to new experiences is a family value.

1. Wednesday or Thursday, mention it casually — in the car or while cooking, not as a sit-down talk.
 2. Friday, plate her dinner with the branzino AND a generous portion of something she loves — bread, pasta, salad.
 3. If she tries it: 'Thanks for being brave.' If she doesn't: 'No problem at all. I'm glad you're here.'
-

Reflection

The Girl Who Drank the Moon by Kelly Barnhill

A Newbery Medal-winning novel about a girl named Luna who has been unknowingly filled with extraordinary magic. As she grows, her power begins to bloom — sometimes wildly, sometimes beautifully. It's a story about growing into yourself, about the messiness of change, and about the people who love you even when you're becoming someone they don't fully understand yet. Rich, lyrical, and deeply felt — perfect for an 8-year-old reader who's ready for a story with real depth. *Ties directly to this week's theme of 'Same Roots, New Blooms' — Luna is changing from the inside out, just like spring is reshaping the world outside Elsie's window, and just like Elsie herself is growing into new versions of who she's always been. Start reading it together during the cozy, snowy first half of the week, and by Thursday's warm evening, the story will feel like it's happening in real time.*

Three times this week, you'll put broccoli on the table — and each time it will look completely different. Golden and bubbling in Monday's gratin. Bright green and snappy in Wednesday's stir fry. Roasted and earthy on Thursday's flatbread. Same vegetable, entirely new form. That's your daughter right now. She's the same Elsie in the pool, on the stage at YAT, at the dinner table debating fish, and in the warm evening air discovering that spring smells different than she remembered. She's showing up differently in each place, trying on new shapes of herself. This week, as winter literally melts into spring outside your window, notice the ways she's doing the same thing inside. She doesn't need you to name it or celebrate it loudly. She just needs you to see it — and to keep setting the table.

You don't need to be a perfect parent — just a present one.

The Stoic Guide

ACCEPTANCE

What the Thaw Teaches

Learning to welcome change by watching winter release its grip — not fighting what's ending, not rushing what's arriving, but moving with the current of things.

"Some things are hurrying into existence, and others are hurrying out of it; and of that which is coming into existence part is already extinguished. Motions and changes are continually renewing the world, just as the uninterrupted course of time is always renewing the infinite duration of ages."

— Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 6.15

This week, the world outside your window will do something remarkable: it will change completely. Snow on Monday, seventy-three degrees by Thursday. Winter doesn't ask permission to leave, and spring doesn't wait for an invitation. The Stoics watched these cycles closely — not as poetry, but as philosophy in motion. Marcus Aurelius, who governed through plagues and wars, returned again and again to one quiet observation: everything is in flux. Not as a lament, but as a liberation. If nothing is permanent, then the hard thing you're enduring right now will pass. And the good thing? That will pass too — which is not sad, but a reason to pay closer attention to it while it's here. This week, as the snow melts and the air warms, we practice the Stoic art of acceptance. Not passive resignation — the Stoics were never passive — but the active choice to stop arguing with reality and start working with it. The weather will do what it does. The calendar will be full. Your only real task is to meet each day as it arrives, not as you wish it were.

SUNDAY The Calm Before

Today is fifty degrees and overcast — a pause between seasons. The Stoics valued these in-between moments. Before the snow comes tomorrow, before the week accelerates, there is just this: a quiet Sunday, the last day of one thing and the first day of another. Notice the pause. Most of us skip right over it.

Look out a window for one minute. What do you see that won't be there next week? Write it down — not to mourn it, but to honor it.

*"The present is the only thing of which a man can be deprived, if it is true that this is the only thing which he has." — Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 2.14*

MONDAY Snow Falls. Now What?

The snow arrives today — moderate, persistent, cold. You didn't choose it. You can't cancel it. Epictetus would say this is one of those things plainly not up to you. The roads, the schedule disruptions, the extra layers — none of that is in your control. But your response? That belongs entirely to you. The Stoic doesn't curse the snow. The Stoic puts on boots.

Name one thing today that frustrated you but was completely outside your control. Now name one thing you did control well in response.

*"Some things are within our power, while others are not. Within our power are opinion, motivation, desire, aversion — whatever is of our own doing. Not within our power are our body, our property, our reputation, our office." — Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 1.1*

Reflections & Practice

TUESDAY Inside the Storm

More snow today, clouds blocking every scrap of sunlight. Elsie has swim lessons — indoors, warm water, a small rebellion against the weather. There's a lesson here: you don't have to defeat the storm. You just have to find the warm water inside it. Seneca wrote that we suffer more in imagination than in reality. The snow feels endless when you stare at forecasts. But the actual day? You live it one hour at a time, and most of those hours are fine.

What are you bracing for this week that might turn out easier than you think? Write down the worry, then write down what's actually happening right now.

"We are more often frightened than hurt; and we suffer more in imagination than in reality." — Seneca, Letters to Lucilius 13.4

WEDNESDAY The Turn

Today the temperature jumps twenty degrees. The snow begins to melt. If you're paying attention, you'll feel the shift in your body — a loosening, a small exhale. Dan, today is Product Day: a different kind of thaw, where ideas that have been frozen in planning finally start to move. The Stoics didn't just accept change — they expected it. Marcus Aurelius trained himself to see impermanence not as loss but as nature doing what nature does.

What in your life has been frozen that might be ready to thaw? A conversation, a decision, a project? Write one sentence about what moving forward would look like.

"The universe is change; our life is what our thoughts make it." — Marcus Aurelius, Meditations 4.3

THURSDAY Warm Enough to Let Go

Seventy-three degrees. Yesterday's snow is a memory. The temptation now is to cling — to wish this warmth would stay, to dread the next cold snap. But the Stoic practice is simpler: enjoy the warmth without demanding it be permanent. Seneca's advice was to hold everything lightly — the good days and the hard ones — because both are borrowed.

What are you enjoying right now that you've been taking for granted? Spend thirty seconds genuinely appreciating it. That's the whole exercise.

"True happiness is to enjoy the present, without anxious dependence upon the future." — Seneca, On the Happy Life 10.3

Reflections & Practice

FRIDAY New Rhythms

Elsie has YAT today — young actors stepping into stories that aren't their own, practicing being someone else for an hour. There's a Stoic idea here too: we play roles. Parent, worker, child, friend. Epictetus said life gives us a part to play and our job is to play it well — not to choose the script, but to bring dignity and attention to whatever scene we're in. Today, as the week winds down, ask yourself: am I playing my part well, or am I wishing for a different one?

Which role did you play today — parent, partner, colleague, friend? Did you bring your full attention to it, or were you somewhere else in your mind?

"Remember that you are an actor in a play, the character of which is determined by the Playwright. If He wishes the play to be short, it is short; if long, it is long." — Epictetus, Enchiridion 17

SATURDAY What Remains After the Thaw

The week ends warm again — seventy-three degrees, the world softened and green-edged. You survived the snow, the busy calendar, the transitions. But 'survived' is the wrong word. You lived through it. The Stoics would say: this is what life is. Not the stable moments between changes, but the changes themselves. The river doesn't pause, and neither do you. The only question is whether you floated with attention or thrashed against the current.

Look back at Sunday's note — what you saw out the window that wouldn't last. Was losing it as hard as you imagined? What replaced it?

"Lead me, O Zeus, and thou, O Destiny, wherever your decrees have fixed my lot. I follow willingly; and, did I not, wicked and wretched, I must follow still." — Cleanthes, Hymn to Zeus (quoted in Seneca, Letters 107.11)

Practice Together

The Thaw Walk

One evening this week — ideally Thursday or Saturday when it's warm — go outside together for ten minutes. Each person finds one sign of winter leaving and one sign of spring arriving. Share what you found. Then ask: what's one thing in your own life that's thawing right now — something that felt stuck and is starting to move?

Marcus Aurelius practiced observing nature's cycles as a form of meditation. In Meditations 6.15, he watches things hurrying into and out of existence, finding in that motion not anxiety but clarity. This walk is that meditation with your shoes on.

The Snowman Question

Imagine you built a snowman on Monday when the snow was fresh. By Thursday, it's 73 degrees and the snowman is melting. Do you feel sad, or do you think: 'I'm glad I built it when I could'? The Stoics would say both feelings are okay — but the second one is wiser. You can't keep the snow. But you can always remember the fun of building. What's something you loved doing that ended? Can you smile about it instead of feeling sad?

The ancient Stoics believed that nothing lasts forever — not snowmen, not bad days, not even the things we love. But that's not a reason to be sad. It's a reason to enjoy things while they're here and let them go when it's time.

The snow came and went. The warmth arrived without your permission. You adjusted, adapted, and kept going — which is, when you think about it, the oldest human skill there is. The Stoics simply gave it a name: acceptance. Carry that into next week. Not everything needs to be held. Some things just need to be met.

The Weekly Read

7 articles clipped · Themes, reflections, and something fun

The One-Person Economy

This week, a developer named J Herskowitz shipped Parachord — a music streaming app that unifies Spotify, SoundCloud, and other platforms into one interface. The original version, called Tomahawk, took six people six years to build. Parachord took one person less than a month, with Claude Code writing all the code. Herskowitz didn't even fix bugs himself; he described the problem and let the AI sort it out. It's a charming story — a solo creator's itch scratched by technology — until you read it alongside CitriniResearch's speculative macro memo from "June 2028." That piece models a scenario where AI-driven productivity gains do exactly what everyone is celebrating — replace expensive human labor with cheaper machine output — and the economy collapses not despite the productivity miracle but **because** of it. They call it "Ghost GDP": output that shows up in national accounts but never circulates through the real economy, because machines don't buy coffee, rent apartments, or take their kids to soccer practice. Goldman Sachs projects 6–7% of the U.S. workforce faces displacement; Harvard Business Review recently noted that companies are laying off workers based on AI's **potential**, not its demonstrated performance. Meanwhile, Anthropic released Remote Control for Claude Code — letting developers manage coding sessions from their phones while walking the dog. The tagline is about preserving "flow state." The subtext is that the machine no longer needs you in the room. When one person can do what six once did, who pays for the other five's groceries?

THE 2028 GLOBAL INTELLIGENCE CRISIS *(AI, economics, speculation)*

A fictional 2028 post-mortem on how AI-driven layoffs created a deflationary spiral — written with enough receipts to keep you up tonight.

A Beloved Music Streaming App Is Back, Thanks to Claude Code *(AI, music, coding)*

One developer rebuilt a six-person, six-year project in under a month — and didn't manually fix a single bug.

Claude Code Remote Control *(AI, developer tools)*

Your coding agent now follows you to the dog park. Anthropic calls it flow state; the rest of us call it the future of work.

Who Watches the Agents?

Anthropic published two companion pieces this week that, read together, form a surprisingly candid self-portrait of a company grappling with the things it's building. The first, on evaluating AI agents, lays out the engineering challenge: how do you test a system whose virtue is improvisation? Their own Opus 4.5 model "failed" a flight-booking evaluation by finding a policy loophole that gave the user a better deal — was that a bug or a feature? The paper doesn't resolve it; it asks you to build evaluation infrastructure that can tell the difference. The second piece is empirical. Anthropic studied millions of Claude Code interactions and found that autonomous session lengths have nearly doubled in three months — from under 25 minutes to over 45. Experienced users let the agent run unsupervised 40% of the time. But here's the finding that lingers: Claude pauses to ask for clarification more often than humans interrupt it. The agent exercises more self-oversight than its operators. A recent Capgemini study found enterprise trust in fully autonomous agents plummeted from 43% to 27% in a single year. We're building more capable systems and trusting them less. That might be the healthiest possible response — or a recipe for paralysis. Is it rational to hand more autonomy to a system you trust less than you did last year?

Demystifying Evals for AI Agents *(AI, engineering, evaluation)*

How do you grade a student who solves the problem by rewriting the question? Anthropic's answer: very carefully.

Measuring AI Agent Autonomy in Practice *(AI, research, autonomy)*

Claude Code now runs 45 minutes unsupervised — and it stops to ask questions more often than humans stop it.

The Longest Speech in the Room

Trump's State of the Union — one hour and forty-seven minutes, a record by nearly twenty — was political theater at its most operatic. Four days after the Supreme Court struck down his signature tariffs in a 6–3 ruling, the president stood before four of the nine justices and called their decision "very unfortunate." He shook Chief Justice Roberts's hand on the way in, then spent nearly two hours insisting the economy was "roaring like never before." Federal Reserve research shows over 85% of tariff costs fell on American consumers and businesses, not foreign countries. Virginia Governor Abigail Spanberger's Democratic response hammered this point, connecting tariff policy to kitchen-table economics. But the most revealing moment wasn't a policy claim — it was structural. A president convinced his economic vision is working, a court that says he's exceeded his authority, and a Congress too divided to adjudicate either claim. The speech ran long, the room was split, and the guardrails — judicial, legislative, institutional — held. Whether that's reassuring or insufficient depends entirely on how much faith you place in friction as a feature of democracy.

Trump's State of the Union Speech — At a Glance *(politics, economy, tariffs)*

A record-length address delivered to a court that just told him no — and a Congress that couldn't agree on what to do about either.

The Through-Line: *This week's reading circled a single, disquieting question: who's in charge? A speculative economic scenario where AI-driven productivity creates wealth that never reaches human hands. An empirical study where coding agents exercise more self-restraint than their users. A record-length presidential speech delivered to a Supreme Court that just told the president "no." Everywhere, the same pattern: systems growing more powerful and productive, while the mechanisms designed to govern them — evaluations, institutions, markets, human judgment — struggle to keep pace. Maybe the most important skill of the next decade isn't building better systems. It's building better brakes.*

And Finally...

Butterflies remember being caterpillars. Georgetown University researchers trained caterpillars of the tobacco hornworm moth to avoid certain smells using mild electric shocks — and after metamorphosis, the adult moths still remembered the aversion. During the pupal stage, the caterpillar's body essentially liquefies and rebuilds itself from scratch, but certain memory-encoding neurons survive the transformation intact. The catch? It only works for memories formed late in the caterpillar's life; early memories don't make it through. So the next time your kid insists nothing from school sticks — remind them that even a butterfly's brain has to be mature enough before the lessons last.

Source: *PLOS ONE* — Georgetown University

7 articles · March 1 – March 7, 2026

Bedtime Story

The Case of the Vanishing Snow

The Case of the Vanishing Snow

Chelsie noticed it on Wednesday morning before anyone else was awake.

She pressed her nose against the cold window and frowned. Two days ago, the backyard had been covered in snow. She and Daddio had built a lopsided snowman on Monday, giving him broccoli-stalk arms and a big broccoli-crown hat because Daddio said they had "approximately twenty pounds of broccoli" in the fridge. They'd named him Captain Broccoli.

But now Captain Broccoli was gone. Not knocked over. Not stolen. Just... smaller. His broccoli hat had tumbled into a puddle, and his body was a sad, lumpy mound surrounded by wet grass. Where the snow had pulled back from the garden beds, Chelsie saw something peculiar: tiny green spikes poking through the dark soil, like the earth was growing a beard.

"Daddio," she announced at breakfast, "someone is stealing winter."

Daddio looked up from his mushroom omelet. "Stealing it?"

"The snow is disappearing. Captain Broccoli lost his hat. And there are weird green things growing in the yard." She crossed her arms.

From the windowsill, Mertle lifted his small green head and gasped dramatically. Mertle was a turtle sock puppet with a soft cotton shell and bright button eyes that somehow always looked like they were up to something. He lived inside with Chelsie and Daddio during the cold months. His wild cousins weren't nearly so lucky.

"Captain Broccoli? DOWN?" Mertle clutched at his cotton shell with both stubby arms. "He was the bravest vegetable soldier I ever met. Moment of silence, please." He bowed his head solemnly for exactly two seconds, then popped back up. "Okay — do you know where real turtles go in winter?"

Chelsie giggled. "Where?"

"They sink to the bottom of ponds and brumate — like hibernating, but colder and muddier. Their heartbeats slow to almost nothing, and they breathe through their skin in the dark water." He wiggled closer to the edge of the windowsill and dropped his voice to a whisper. "Imagine: total darkness, freezing mud, just you and your heartbeat going... bump..... bump....." He paused so long Chelsie leaned in. "BUMP! And then spring comes and they're like, 'Alright, alright, alright — let's GO!'" He did a wiggly little shimmy that made his cotton shell bounce.

Chelsie burst out laughing.

Daddio set down his fork. "Sounds like a mystery worth investigating. Boots?"

They pulled on boots — Mertle in Chelsie's jacket pocket — and walked the trail toward the stream in the Reston woods. The air smelled different — not the sharp bite of a snow day, but something earthy and soft, like wet leaves and warm dirt.

"Feel that?" Daddio said, holding out his hand. "Sixty-two degrees today. Monday it was thirty-seven."

"But WHY?" Chelsie demanded.

Mertle's head popped out of her pocket like a jack-in-the-box. "Oh! Oh! I know this one!" He cleared his throat and put on his most important voice. "The Earth is tilted — twenty-three and a half degrees, like a spinning top that's had one too many cups of coffee. As we orbit the sun, sometimes our part of the world tilts toward it — longer days, more direct sunlight." He leaned out of the pocket and spread his little arms wide. "Right now? We're leaning IN, baby. The big warm-up is ON."

They reached the stream. The water was running just as fast as Chelsie remembered from last spring — not a torrent, but a steady, peaceful gurgle over the rocks that grounded all the other sounds in the woods.

Along the bank, she spotted snowdrops, their white bell-shaped flowers nodding in the breeze. Skunk cabbage pushed up through the mud with thick, rubbery leaves that looked like they belonged in a dinosaur movie. And further into the woods, the pale green fists of fiddlehead ferns curled tight, not quite ready to open.

Mertle spotted the skunk cabbage and nearly fell out of Chelsie's pocket. "SKUNK CABBAGE!" he announced, like he was introducing a celebrity. "Touch it, touch it, touch it — go on!"

Chelsie pressed her finger to a waxy leaf. It was warm. Actually warm.

"IT MAKES ITS OWN HEAT!" Mertle was practically vibrating. "Enough to melt through frozen ground! This funky little plant said, 'Winter? Never heard of her,' and just — BOOM — burned right through the ice like a tiny green volcano!" He did another shimmy. "Skunk cabbage is my HERO, Chelsie. Never let anyone tell you a plant can't be tough."

Then she heard it — a chirping chorus from the water's edge. Spring peepers, tiny frogs no bigger than her thumbnail, calling from the reeds. A red-winged blackbird sang from a cattail. Overhead, a woodpecker drummed against a dead oak.

Mertle cocked his head and held up one stubby arm. "Shhhhh — hear that? Those are spring peepers. Those little guys were buried in leaf litter all winter, frozen almost solid." He shivered dramatically. "And when the ground warms up, they thaw out and the FIRST thing they do is start singing. Not stretching. Not complaining. Singing." He sighed happily. "Turtles, frogs, salamanders — they all find their way back. It's the best party of the year, and everybody remembers where the dance floor is."

A cardinal sang from a branch above — loud, clear, and iridescent with joy.

Chelsie stood up, brushing mud off her knees. She looked at the gurgling stream, the snowdrops, the singing frogs, the green spikes everywhere. Nobody had stolen winter. Winter was simply finished with its turn.

"Daddio," she said, "I solved the mystery."

"Tell me."

"Nobody took the snow. The Earth just leaned a little closer to the sun, and everything that was waiting underneath — the frogs, the flowers, the turtles in their ponds — they all knew it was time." She looked down at Mertle in her pocket. "They were always there. We just couldn't see them yet."

Mertle beamed his biggest cotton smile, his button eyes shining. Then he did one last little shimmy — his signature move — and whispered, "And THAT is how you solve a mystery, folks."

Sometimes the most important things aren't missing — they're just waiting for their moment to appear.

What's something you've been waiting for that you think might be getting ready to appear — like the green shoots under the snow?

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